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From Civvies to Uniform

The call letter to join the NDA 56th Course, Autumn Term, commencing July 1976, finally came, but with a twist. Instead of reporting to NDA, Khadakwasla, Pune, I was to report to the NDA Wing at the Officer Training School (OTS—now Officer Training Academy), Madras (now Chennai). Those few weeks of waiting were quite worrying because I had not applied for or given any entrance exams for any other course or institution. Had I not got into the NDA, I would have been out on a limb and lost a year. My father being in the Services had, of course, been a key factor in my wanting to follow in his footsteps; my mother, though, wasn't too keen on sending her *laadka* (favourite son) to the Army, as she felt I was more suited for an intellectual life. Had it not been for the NDA, I probably would have become an architect, as I had been quite impressed by the character of Howard Roark, in Ayn Rand's *The Fountainhead*. However, once she knew that my mind was made up, that it was my choice and not under any pressure from my father, she steeled her heart and supported me wholeheartedly. My father was in the Air Force, but he had originally been an

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